TAQA Bid Analyser

User Manual

Version 1.1 | October 2026

A complete guide to comparing vendor bids, reading the automated checks, and recording your own findings.

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1. About This Manual

This manual explains how to use the TAQA Bid Analyser: what each screen shows, what every flag means, which numbers you can rely on, and which ones need your judgement before you act on them.

It is written for the procurement analysts who evaluate vendor bids. It assumes you know the commercial side of tender evaluation. It does not assume any technical knowledge of Maximo, Databricks or spreadsheets beyond ordinary use.

How to read this manual

- If you are new to the tool, read chapters 2 through 7 in order. That covers finding a tender, opening it, and reading the comparison.
- If you want to understand a specific flag, go straight to the flag reference in chapter 14.
- Chapter 13 lists what the tool deliberately does not do. Read it before you rely on the tool for anything that matters.

> Throughout this manual, anything marked Important describes behaviour that could mislead you if you are not aware of it. These are not warnings about bugs. They describe deliberate design decisions whose reasoning matters.

What changed in this version

- Chapter 5 is new: you can now upload vendor spreadsheets directly instead of only using tenders already in Maximo. This is a beta feature and is labelled as such.
- Chapter 6 covers the new switch between unit rates and line totals in the comparison.
- Chapter 11 reflects a correction: the negotiation report now prices at the latest negotiation round. It previously used the original quote.

2. What the Tool Does

The Bid Analyser automates the comparison stage of tender evaluation. It presents vendor bids line by line, so work you would otherwise do by hand in a spreadsheet is done for you and checked consistently.

The manual process it replaces

The established process for analysing a bid runs roughly as follows:

1. Download bid offers from the Maximo portal.
2. Copy every bidder's prices into a consolidated comparison spreadsheet.
3. Check each line for unquoted items, arithmetic errors and changed descriptions.
4. Look for unbalanced bidding, where a vendor front-loads cost onto early items.
5. Prepare negotiation notes per bidder, listing outliers and over or under pricing.
6. Repeat the comparison after each negotiation round.

The Bid Analyser performs steps 2 through 5 automatically and keeps step 6 to a single click. It does not replace your judgement at any point. It surfaces what deserves attention and leaves the decision to you.

Where the pricing comes from

There are two routes, and you choose between them when you create a project:

Route	Use it when	Status
Maximo RFQ	The tender and its vendor pricing are already in Maximo. This is the normal route and the one to use for any evaluation that counts.	Full release
Excel upload	You hold the vendors' priced spreadsheets but the pricing is not in Maximo.	Beta, see chapter 5

What it never changes

The tool reads tender and vendor bid data from Maximo. It never writes anything back. Every price correction, disqualification and partial bid flag you record is stored separately, inside the application only, and is invisible to Maximo and to anyone working in Maximo.

> **Important:** because nothing is written back, a correction you make here does not fix the underlying record. If a price in Maximo is wrong, it is still wrong in Maximo after you correct it in the Bid Analyser. Raise it through the normal channel as well.

3. Getting Started

Access

The Bid Analyser runs as an application inside TAQA's Databricks workspace. To open it you need two things:

1. Access to the Databricks workspace itself.
2. Access granted to you on the specific application.

Both are granted by a workspace administrator. If the link does not open for you, that is an access request, not a fault with the tool.

Identifying yourself

The first time you open the tool it asks for your name. This is used to label the work you do: when you correct a price or disqualify a line, your name appears against that action so colleagues reviewing the same tender can see who made the change and ask you about it.

> **Important:** this is a label, not a login. The tool does not verify who you are. Access control is handled entirely by the Databricks workspace, which you already had to pass to reach this page. Two people entering the same name will share one identity in the tool, so use your real name consistently.

You can change the name later using the switch user link in the top right of the Projects page.

The main areas

Area	What it is for
Browse RFQs	Finding a tender in Maximo. Search and filter the full list.
Projects	Your working list. A project pins one tender so you can return to it.
Project detail	The analysis itself, split across three tabs: BOQ Comparison, Round Tracking and Negotiation Report.
Upload workspace	Only for uploaded projects. Where you add, review and confirm vendor spreadsheets before the analysis opens.

4. Finding a Tender in Maximo

Browsing RFQs

The Browse RFQs page lists every RFQ available in Maximo. You can narrow the list three ways, and they combine:

- Search, by RFQ number or by words in the description.
- Organisation, covering ADDC, TRANS, AADC, ADWEA, AMPC, ADSSC and BPC.
- BOQ category, described below.

BOQ categories

Not every RFQ in Maximo has pricing detailed enough to compare line by line. The tool sorts them into four categories so you do not open a tender only to find there is nothing to analyse:

Category	What it means for you
Detailed BOQ	Full line item pricing from multiple vendors. This is what the comparison is built for.
Shallow	Some pricing present, but thin. The comparison will work but will have little to say.
Lump-sum	Priced as a single total rather than itemised. Line by line comparison is not possible.
No pricing data	No vendor pricing recorded. Nothing to compare.

> **Important:** these categories are calculated by counting the actual priced lines each vendor submitted. They are not taken from the detailed BOQ available flag in Maximo, which was tested during the build and found unreliable.

Creating a project

A project is a saved pointer to one tender, so you and your colleagues can find it again without searching. From the Projects page choose New project, then choose Select an RFQ from Maximo, pick the tender from the browsable table, name it and create it.

Projects are shared. A project created by one analyst is visible to everyone using the tool.

5. Uploading Vendor Spreadsheets

Use this route when you hold the bidders' priced spreadsheets but their pricing is not in Maximo. The tool reads the spreadsheets, you check and correct what it read, and once you confirm it feeds the same three analysis tabs a Maximo tender does.

> **Important:** this feature is marked BETA throughout the interface and is under active testing. Check every extracted figure before confirming. Uploaded BOQs are held in the running application and are lost if it restarts, so do not treat the tool as a record of them. Use the Maximo route for any evaluation that counts.

What you need

- One spreadsheet per vendor per round. A vendor who bid an original and two negotiation rounds is three files.
- Files in .xlsx or .xlsm format. Legacy .xls and PDF submissions are not supported.
- Each file no larger than 25MB.

Adding files

1. From the Projects page choose New project, then Upload vendor Excel files, give the project a name and create it.
2. For each file, enter the vendor code, optionally a display name, and choose the round. Upload each vendor's original submission first, then any later rounds.
3. The tool extracts the priced lines and adds them to a single shared BOQ.

How lines are matched across vendors

Vendors each submit their own file, so the tool has to work out which of their lines are the same BOQ item. It matches on the BOQ item number, which the ADDC template standardises. Where a vendor has stripped that column, it falls back to an exact match on the description text.

> **Important:** matching is never fuzzy, because a near match on a BOQ description would silently merge two genuinely different items. The consequence is that a vendor who renumbered their items may produce duplicate lines rather than matched ones. The review screen is where you catch that.

The extraction cross-check

For each file the tool compares the lines it extracted against the vendor's own summary sheet and reports whether they agree. A file that does not reconcile is worth opening before you go further. It means either the extraction missed something, or the vendor's own summary contradicts their own priced detail, which happens more often than you might expect.

Reviewing and confirming

The review table shows every extracted line with each vendor and round as a column, so you can see the whole picture before committing to it. Until you confirm, you can:

- Edit a line's description, unit or quantity. Changing the quantity recalculates every vendor's total for that line.

- Delete a line that should not be there.
- Remove an uploaded file and everything it contributed.

Choose Confirm and open analysis when the BOQ looks right. Confirming locks editing and opens the three analysis tabs. If you need to change something afterwards, use Reopen for editing.

> **Important:** the analysis tabs refuse to open an unconfirmed BOQ. That is deliberate. A half-reviewed extraction should not be driving an evaluation.

6. The BOQ Comparison

This is the core of the tool and where you will spend most of your time. It shows every BOQ line down the page and every vendor across it, so you can read a line horizontally to compare bidders, or read a column vertically to understand one vendor's approach.

The vendor summary

Above the line table sits one row per vendor showing:

- Contract total, being the sum of that vendor's priced lines.
- Flags, being a count of the issues found in their bid, such as unquoted lines or arithmetic errors.
- A Lowest badge on the cheapest full scope bid.

Below that, the tool lists vendors who were invited but submitted no pricing at all. They are kept visible deliberately. A vendor declining to bid is information worth having, and it is easy to forget a name that simply is not in the table.

Unit rates or line totals

A checkbox below the legend, Show unit rates instead of line totals, switches every price cell between the two. Each vendor column header says which of the two it is currently showing.

View	Shows	Use it for
Line total	Unit rate multiplied by quantity. The default.	Seeing what a line is worth and how totals build up.
Unit rate	The price for one unit.	Negotiating, and comparing a rate against what you have seen on other tenders. A unit rate is comparable in a way a quantity-dependent total is not.

Switching the view changes only what is displayed. The cheapest and priciest colouring follows whichever figure is on screen, so the green marker is always on the lowest of what you are actually looking at.

> **Important:** a price correction is always entered as a unit rate, whichever view you are in. The edit box is labelled to remind you. Entering a line total there would be wrong by a factor of the quantity.

Reading a price cell

Each cell shows one vendor's figure for one line. Colour and symbols carry meaning. The legend sits above the table and the full reference is in chapter 14.

Hovering over a cell reveals the actions available on it, and hovering over any flag shows a plain language explanation of why that flag was applied.

Large BOQs

The on screen table shows the first 500 lines. Every total, count and flag is still calculated across the complete BOQ, so the vendor summary and the negotiation report remain correct no matter how long the BOQ is. Only the visible list is shortened.

Switching rounds

If the tender has been through negotiation rounds, a round selector appears above the table. Changing it reloads the comparison as it stood at that round, so you can see exactly what each vendor was offering at that point.

7. Understanding the Flags

The flags are the tool's main contribution. Each one replaces a check you would otherwise do by hand. This chapter explains what each means and, just as importantly, what each does not mean.

Cheapest and priciest on line

The lowest and highest price on that line, among vendors who actually quoted it. Zero priced and disqualified cells are excluded from this comparison, so the cheapest marker never lands on a line a vendor simply failed to price.

Arithmetic error

Quantity multiplied by unit rate does not equal the line total the vendor stated. This catches transcription and formula errors in the vendor's own spreadsheet. A tolerance of 0.01 is applied, so genuine rounding at the second decimal place is not flagged.

Unquoted

The vendor left the line blank. Counted per vendor in the summary row, because a bid missing many lines is not directly comparable with a complete one.

AED 0, likely missing

The vendor entered zero rather than leaving the line blank. Treated separately from unquoted because the two are different: a zero may be a genuine no charge item, or it may be an omission. The tool cannot tell which, so it flags it for you to decide.

Outlier

This is the most useful flag and the one most worth understanding properly.

An outlier is not simply an expensive line. A vendor whose pricing sits two or three times above the group across the whole BOQ is not an outlier, that is just their price level. Flagging every one of their lines would be noise.

Instead the tool compares each line against that vendor's own typical relationship to the rest of the field. It asks whether this line is unusual for them. That is the unbalanced bidding concept from the business case: a vendor loading cost onto particular items while pricing the rest normally.

How it is calculated

1. For each line, the tool finds the median price across vendors who quoted it.
2. For each vendor, it calculates how their price on that line compares with that median, giving a ratio.
3. It then establishes that vendor's typical ratio across the whole BOQ.
4. A line is a candidate when its ratio sits far from that vendor's own typical ratio, measured by a modified z-score above a threshold of 3.
5. Of all candidates on a single line, only the strongest is flagged.

When no outlier flag appears

The tool deliberately stays silent rather than guessing in three situations:

- Fewer than three vendors quoted the line, so there is no meaningful median.

- The vendor has fewer than five comparable lines, so there is no reliable baseline for what is typical for them.
- Another vendor on the same line scored higher. Only one outlier is flagged per line, because one vendor's extreme price can drag the median enough to make an otherwise normal second vendor look anomalous.

> **Important:** no outlier flag does not mean the line is fine. It may mean the tool did not have enough data to judge. Treat the flag as a prompt to look, never the absence of one as a clearance.

Technically disqualified

The line is excluded from commercial evaluation. There are two possible sources, and the distinction matters.

From Maximo

Maximo has marked the line as technically not acceptable. This comes from the technical evaluation and cannot be changed in the Bid Analyser. If you believe it is wrong, that is a conversation with the technical evaluators, not something to override here.

Entered by an analyst

You or a colleague disqualified the line in the tool, with a reason. Your name and reason are shown against it.

> **Important:** a manual entry can only ever add a disqualification. It can never remove one that came from Maximo. If the technical evaluation rejected a line, no action in this tool will bring it back into the commercial comparison.

What exclusion actually does

- The line is not counted as unquoted against the vendor.
- It cannot be marked cheapest or priciest.
- It is removed from the vendor's contract total.

Manually corrected

A price on this line was edited by an analyst. The marker shows who changed it, when, and any note they left. The original value is never destroyed, so the correction is always traceable.

8. Recording Your Own Findings

Three actions let you record judgement the automated checks cannot make. All three are stored inside the application only and are never sent to Maximo.

Correcting a price

Use this when the figure in Maximo does not match the vendor's actual submission, typically a transcription error.

1. Hover over the price cell and choose the correction action.
2. Enter the corrected unit rate. Not the line total, whichever view you are in.
3. Add a note explaining why. This is optional but strongly recommended, because a correction without a reason is hard for a colleague to review.

The comparison recalculates immediately. Totals, cheapest and priciest markers and outlier scores all update to reflect the corrected figure.

> **Important:** corrections apply to the original round only. Round by round pricing comes from Maximo's own discount history and is not editable here. This also means a correction does not affect the negotiation report on a tender that has been through negotiation, because that report prices at the latest round. See chapter 11.

Disqualifying a line

Use this when a line should be excluded from commercial evaluation for a reason the technical evaluation did not capture.

1. Hover over the cell and choose the disqualify action.
2. Enter a reason. This is how a colleague understands your decision later.

The effect is identical to a Maximo disqualification: the line leaves the commercial comparison entirely. It can be undone, since it is your entry, unlike one from Maximo.

Marking a partial bid

Use this when a vendor was only ever expected to price part of the BOQ, for example because they bid on one lot only. Without it, that vendor looks like a complete bid riddled with missing lines, and their total looks deceptively low.

Tick Partial bid against the vendor in the summary. Three things change:

- Their unquoted lines stop counting against them, because those lines were never in their scope.
- Their contract total is relabelled to show it covers part of the BOQ, with the number of lines they priced.
- They are removed from the Lowest badge comparison, so a partial bid cannot win on an incomplete total.

> **Important:** a partial bid flag applies to the whole vendor, not to individual lines. The tool does not record which parts of the BOQ were in their scope, so use the note field to capture that.

9. Round Tracking

The Round Tracking tab shows how each vendor's pricing has moved across negotiation rounds, reconstructed from Maximo's discount history, or from the rounds you uploaded.

The trend table

One row per vendor, one column per round, showing their total at each stage. This answers the basic question of who moved, by how much, and who did not move at all.

Anomalous movement flags

Below the trend, the tool flags movements that deserve explanation. They come at two severities, which you can filter.

Critical: a price went up

A vendor increased a price between rounds. Negotiation rounds are expected to move prices down, so any material increase is worth asking about directly. Increases below one dirham are ignored as rounding noise.

Warning: a discount far steeper than peers

A vendor dropped a line price far more sharply than other vendors did on the same line. This is not necessarily wrong, but it is worth understanding. It can indicate an error in the original price, a change in assumed scope, or a bid being bought.

This flag requires at least three vendors on the line for comparison. With fewer, there is no reliable peer movement to compare against and the tool stays silent.

> **Important:** these thresholds are first pass values set during the build. They have not yet been tuned against a large volume of real negotiation history. If you find them too noisy or too quiet in practice, that is useful feedback and the values can be adjusted.

10. The Negotiation Report

The Negotiation Report tab turns the analysis into preparation material for a negotiation meeting.

Which round it reflects

The report prices at the latest negotiation round, not the original quote. The round it used is stated at the top of the page and on the first line of the Excel export.

> **Important:** this was corrected in October 2026. Earlier versions of the report used the original quote regardless of how many rounds had taken place, which meant totals and rankings ignored every discount since. If you took a report from the tool before that date, re-run it.

What it contains

- Vendors ranked by contract total, with each one's percentage above the lowest bid.
- Up to eight priority issues per vendor, selected automatically.
- The list of invited vendors who did not submit.

How issues are prioritised

When a vendor has more than eight issues, the tool keeps the ones most worth raising, in this order:

Priority	Issue	Why it ranks here
1	Price increased between rounds	Hardest to explain, most direct to raise.
2	Arithmetic error	Objective and indisputable.
3	Steep discount versus peers	Suggests the original price needs explaining.
4	Unquoted line	A gap in the bid that must be closed.
5	Outlier	Possible unbalanced bidding.
6	AED 0 price	Likely an omission, needs confirming.

Excel export

Download Excel produces the same content as a spreadsheet you can circulate, annotate or take into a meeting. It is generated fresh each time from current data, and names the round it covers on its first line.

> **Important:** the report ranks vendors by price and lists issues. It does not recommend an award, and it does not account for financial standing, delivery capacity or current workload. Those remain entirely your assessment.

> **Important:** the report does not yet account for partial bids. A partial bidder's total may appear in the ranking without the caveat the comparison tab shows. Check the comparison tab before relying on the ranking.

11. The AI Features

The tool includes two optional AI features. Both run on a model hosted inside TAQA's own Databricks workspace. No bid data is sent to any external provider.

Neither runs automatically. Both require you to press a button, and neither is saved. This is deliberate: AI output should be something you asked for and evaluated, not something that appears alongside real figures and is mistaken for them.

AI summary, on the Negotiation Report tab

Produces a short written overview of the bidding landscape, per vendor observations and talking points for the negotiation.

This feature is tightly constrained. It is permitted to describe only figures already present in the report. It cannot introduce a number of its own. After it responds, the tool checks its output and silently removes any reference to a vendor not actually bidding on this tender, noting the removal.

It deliberately does not recommend an award.

AI generated prices, on the BOQ Comparison tab

Adds a column estimating a fair price for each line. Press Generate AI prices to produce it; the column does not exist until you do. It follows the unit rate and line total switch like every other price column.

This feature works in the opposite way to the AI summary and the difference is important. It is explicitly asked to produce its own independent estimate from general knowledge of construction and material costs, using the vendor quotes only as background. The resulting figure is therefore an invented number with no verifiable source behind it.

Treat it as the opinion of an experienced estimator asked for a quick view without time to research. It is a sense check on whether the field is pricing sensibly. It is not a benchmark, not a market rate, and not something to quote to a vendor.

Confidence levels

Every estimate reports its own confidence, shown by the shading of the figure and in full when you hover. Where the model did not clearly state a confidence, the tool records it as low rather than assuming otherwise.

Scope

Estimates cover the first 60 lines of the BOQ. On a longer BOQ the remaining lines have no estimate.

When the model is unavailable

If the model cannot be reached, times out, or returns something unusable, the tool falls back to the median of the vendor prices already quoted on that line, so the column still fills. A line nobody quoted receives no estimate, because there is nothing to base one on.

> **Important:** a fallback figure is calculated from the vendor prices sitting beside it on the same line. It will often equal one of them exactly. When it does, that is arithmetic, not the AI independently arriving at the same number, and it is not corroboration of any vendor's price. The column does not distinguish fallback figures from model estimates on screen.

12. What the Tool Does Not Do

Knowing the limits matters as much as knowing the features. None of the following are faults. They are either deliberate scope decisions or known gaps.

Evaluation scope

- It does not recommend an award. It ranks by price and lists issues; the decision is yours.
- It does not assess financial standing, capacity or current project load, all of which form part of a full evaluation.
- It does not compare technical submissions. It handles the commercial side only.

Bid documents

- It does not read PDF submissions. Where a vendor submitted a PDF that was never transcribed, the tool cannot see those prices. Excel submissions can now be uploaded directly, see chapter 5.

Structure

- It does not subtotal by lot. Maximo holds no lot structure for a multi lot tender, so a contract total is a flat sum across all of a vendor's lines.
- It does not detect changed descriptions. A vendor altering an item's wording is a manual check that remains yours.

Editing

- It offers no bulk actions. Corrections, disqualifications and partial bid flags are recorded one at a time.
- It has no single screen listing every manual override on a tender. Each is visible on its own cell.

Writing back

- Nothing you do in the tool reaches Maximo, ever. Anything that needs correcting at source must also be raised through the normal process.

13. Flag Reference

A single page summary of every marker in the BOQ comparison.

Flag	Meaning	What to do
Cheapest on line	Lowest price among vendors who quoted it.	Check it is not low because scope was missed.
Priciest on line	Highest price among vendors who quoted it.	Compare against the outlier flag before raising it.
Arithmetic error	Quantity times unit rate does not equal the stated line total.	Raise directly. Objective and indisputable.
Unquoted	Vendor left the line blank.	Close the gap, or mark a partial bid if out of scope.
AED 0	Vendor entered zero rather than leaving it blank.	Confirm whether genuinely free or omitted.
Outlier	Unusual for this vendor against their own typical pricing.	Investigate as possible unbalanced bidding.
Technically disqualified	Excluded from commercial evaluation, from Maximo or an analyst.	No action if from Maximo. Check the reason if manual.
Manually corrected	A price was edited in the tool by an analyst.	Check who, when and why on hover.
Partial bid	Vendor was only expected to price part of the BOQ.	Do not compare their total against full scope bids.

14. Troubleshooting

A correction or disqualification will not save

The tool will show a clear message rather than failing silently. The most common cause is that the permission to store analyst entries has not yet been granted on the underlying data platform. This is an administrator action and needs no change to the tool. Pass the message to your technical contact.

A flag I expected is not showing

Check first whether the data supports it. Outlier detection stays silent when fewer than three vendors quoted a line or when a vendor has fewer than five comparable lines. Round flags need at least three vendors on the line. In each case silence means not enough evidence, not a clean result.

The AI price column is missing

It only appears after you press Generate AI prices, and it sits to the right of every vendor column, so on a tender with many vendors you may need to scroll the table sideways to reach it.

The AI summary says it is not set up

The connection to the model is not configured or not permitted for the application. Every other part of the tool continues to work normally. Report it to your technical contact.

A vendor is missing from the comparison

Check the did not submit list below the vendor summary. Vendors who were invited but submitted no pricing appear there rather than in the table.

The tender shows no lines at all

Check its BOQ category on the Browse RFQs page. Lump-sum and no pricing data tenders have nothing to compare line by line.

An uploaded project will not open its analysis tabs

The BOQ has not been confirmed yet. Open the upload workspace, review the extraction and choose Confirm and open analysis.

An uploaded project has disappeared

Uploaded BOQs are held in the running application and are lost when it restarts. This is a known beta limitation. The files on your own machine are unaffected, so the project can be rebuilt by uploading them again.

The same BOQ item appears twice after uploading

Two vendors numbered that item differently, so the tool could not tell they were the same line. Delete the duplicate in the review screen before confirming, or correct the item number so they match.

15. Glossary

Term	Meaning
BOQ	Bill of Quantities. The itemised schedule of work vendors price against.
RFQ	Request for Quotation. One tender.
Line	A single BOQ item, priced by each vendor.
Unit rate	Price for one unit of a line.
Line total	Unit rate multiplied by quantity.
Contract total	Sum of a vendor's line totals across the BOQ.
Round	One stage of negotiation. Vendors may revise pricing at each.
Unbalanced bidding	Loading cost onto particular items while pricing the rest normally.
Outlier	A line unusual for that vendor against their own typical pricing.
Partial bid	A vendor expected to price only part of the BOQ.
Technically disqualified	Excluded from commercial evaluation on technical grounds.
Maximo	The IBM system holding tender and vendor bid records. The tool reads it and never writes to it.
Beta	A feature released for testing. Usable, but not yet guaranteed.